How We Tested

We evaluated each of these software taking various factors into consideration, including:

Ease of use: We looked at the general interface of the programs, and their utility, considered the design and feel, and how easily it could be comprehended by a lay person. We also looked at the documentation available, and the amount and degree of relevant help available to the user, for each menu and function.

Features: Here we looked for any additional utilities and tools that were included with the software, adding functionality. Also, we looked for any particular characteristics present in one tool and absent in the others.

In each of the sections that follow, the bases on which we evaluated the performance of the software is further explained.

The test process for Recovery Tools was very elaborate, and tested almost every aspect of the software. Our test bed consisted of a system with a P4 processor and a Seagate 120 GB SATA hard disk as the primary hard disk, with Windows XP Professional as the operating system. For the actual tests, we attached a 40 GB parallel ATA Seagate hard disk in slave mode. On this test bed, we created a 1 GB partition for the test.

Apart from ease-of-use and features, the performance parameters that we tested were:

Scanning speed: A sample 438 MB folder containing a random collection of Word documents, Excel spreadsheets, HTML files and Zip archives was copied onto the test disk, and then deleted. The time taken by each utility to scan through the partition for the deleted was then noted.

Recovery of deleted files: For this test, we copied a fixed number of files of sizes between 10 KB and 60 KB to the test drive. After deleting these files, the recovery suites were taken through their paces, and the accuracy in both the recovered file sizes and the data within the files was evaluated.

Recovery of entire partition: In this test, we tested for data recovery in the eventuality of loss of data due to a crashed partition. We first created a simple file and folder structure on the test partition. After this, we deleted the whole partition and then used the tools to analyse the raw space on the disk. During this test, we paid particular attention to the recovery of the file and folder system, looking not just at the accuracy of the actual files recovered.

DISK IMAGING SOFTWARE

This category consists of tools that let you create exact images of a hard disk, or specific partitions, that can be used at any later time to restore the PC to the same state as before. They can be used to make exact copies of a disk. One of the main uses of these imaging utilities is to create a replica of your current system on a new system. These utilities also come in handy when you have to quickly migrate your system to a new hard disk—or perhaps onto the same hard disk in a different partition—and do not want to go through the hassle of installing the OS, and then re-installing all your applications.

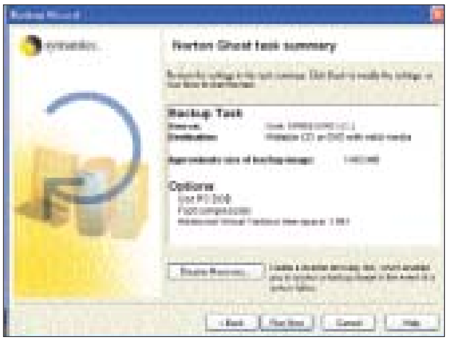
When we tested these imaging utilities, one of the most important parameters was speed, both in creating images and in restoring the image onto the test machine. We tested two products in this category, Norton Ghost 2003 and Drive Image 7.0.

Norton Ghost 2003

Ghost in the machine

Norton Ghost has a very easy-to-use interface. Wizards guide you through all tasks, without exposing the intricacies. There are three categories under which all tasks are grouped—Ghost Basic, Ghost Advanced and Ghost Utilities. Under Ghost Basic come all the basic backup and restore tasks. Ghost Utilities consists of the Norton Ghost Boot Wizard, which helps in creation of a boot disk for various scenarios—restore from removable media, restore from shared folders, or restore from peer-to-peer network. Norton Ghost makes the task of backing up or restoring between two PCs simpler, by providing a peer-to-peer wizard.

The software supports a variety of removable storage media—



Click 'Run Now' to complete the creation of a new task in Norton Ghost 2003

CDs, DVDs, USB drives, ZIP drives and Firewire—onto which the hard disk image can be transferred. It even supports creation of images across a network. Thanks to the Image Integrity Check tool, you won't have to wait until when you have to urgently restore your PC, to find that the image is corrupted. Also, if you're one of those who wouldn't trust a piece of software, you can go ahead and browse the contents of the image using the Norton Ghost Explorer. The explorer also comes in handy when the image is corrupted, and a few important files have to be extracted from it.

Norton Ghost has some additional utilities that come in handy. One of these is the GDisk utility that can be used to create and manage partitions.

Norton Ghost was the slower of the two software in terms of time taken to create an image, but it was, however, able to compress the image file to 52 per cent of original size.

Overall, Norton Ghost is attractive because of its easy-to-use interface and loads of features, but loses out on performance to Drive Image 7.

+ Feature rich, separate image integrity check tool provided
– Very slow operation

Norton Ghost 2003

Performance	
Features	
Ease of use	
Overall	